

Codes of Ethics and Codes of Conduct - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Codes of Ethics and Codes of Conduct

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

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| 1 Why public institutions need both ethical aspiration and conduct control | 2 Code of Ethics versus Code of Conduct: the controlling distinction |
| 3 Translating public-service values into rules, procedures and reasons | 4 Civil-service conduct rules: neutrality, information, speech and outside interests |
| 5 Conflict controls: gifts, hospitality, assets, relatives and recusal | 6 Ministers and legislators: political responsibility, interests and House discipline |
| 7 Institutional ownership: advice, training, monitoring, reporting and periodic review | 8 Enforcement with fairness: sanctions, proof, proportionality and due process |
| 9 Why codes fail: loopholes, ritual compliance and the ethical-competence response | 10 PYQ synthesis, current official anchors and complete answer architecture |

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Codes of Ethics and Codes of Conduct - Solved Practice Workbook	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	27
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	32

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Generation: learner-v2:g1 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A department publishes selflessness, impartiality and service as ideals but states no gift, disclosure or recusal rule. Which kind of code has it mainly created? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- B. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- C. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- D. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.

Answer: A

Explanation: Ethics codes guide aspiration; conduct codes specify behaviour is the controlling principle. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

A service rule fixes when an interest must be declared and what disciplinary process may follow concealment. Which kind of code is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- B. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- C. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
- D. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.

Answer: B

Explanation: Ethics codes guide aspiration; conduct codes specify behaviour is the controlling principle. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

An ethics charter says officials should show empathy. A manager treats the sentence alone as automatic authority to dismiss an employee. Which legal-ethical error arises? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- B. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- C. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- D. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.

Answer: C

Explanation: An aspirational code is not legally self-executing is the controlling principle. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A value is incorporated into a notified conduct rule with a defined breach procedure. What changed its institutional status? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- B. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
- C. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- D. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.

Answer: D

Explanation: An aspirational code is not legally self-executing is the controlling principle. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

A licensing officer argues that a private dinner with a bidder is acceptable because an ordinary citizen may dine with anyone. Which role-based point defeats the argument? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- B. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- C. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- D. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.

Answer: A

Explanation: Public servants face stricter role obligations is the controlling principle. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

Why may a lawful private activity still require restriction or disclosure when an official's public duties are materially connected to it? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- B. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- C. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
- D. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.

Answer: B

Explanation: Public servants face stricter role obligations is the controlling principle. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

A code praises integrity but gives procurement staff no conflict form or recusal route. At which translation stage has the system failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- B. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- C. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.
- D. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Values require a translation chain** is the controlling principle. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

An organisation maps favouritism risk into disclosure, reassignment and audit steps. Which values-to-rules method is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Aspirational ethical language does not by itself create a legal offence, penalty or dismissal power. Enforceability must come from valid law, service rules, contract, House procedure or another competent instrument, applied through fair process.
- B. The Second ARC explains that public servants require standards more stringent than those for an ordinary citizen because public action meets private interest. Office brings entrusted authority, information, money and coercive capacity.
- C. A Code of Ethics states broad public-service values and decision principles, while a Code of Conduct translates selected risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences. They are complementary rather than interchangeable.
- D. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Values require a translation chain** is the controlling principle. A credible ethics system moves from constitutional and public-service values to risk identification, specific conduct rules, operational procedures, records, advice, monitoring, fair enforcement and learning-based revision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A rule bans 'improper association' without definition, examples, advice or reviewing authority. Which rule-of-law defect is most evident? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- B. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- C. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- D. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Rule design must be clear without becoming mechanical** is the controlling principle. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A gift rule defines ordinary exceptions, reporting, valuation and approval while requiring reasons for borderline cases. Which design balance is achieved? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- B. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- C. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
- D. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Rule design must be clear without becoming mechanical** is the controlling principle. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

An official claims neutrality is merely optional professional advice. Which existing conduct-rule architecture contradicts the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- B. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- C. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- D. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.

Answer: C

Explanation: Rule 3 supplies a general civil-service conduct floor is the controlling principle. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

A decision is formally efficient but openly advances the officer's private interest. Which Rule 3 public-interest and conflict standard is implicated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- B. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
- C. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- D. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.

Answer: D

Explanation: Rule 3 supplies a general civil-service conduct floor is the controlling principle. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A civil servant refuses to implement a lawful policy solely because another party adopted it. Is this neutrality or partisan obstruction? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- B. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- C. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- D. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Political neutrality differs from political indifference** is the controlling principle. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

An officer gives candid evidence-based advice, then faithfully implements the lawful ministerial decision. Which conception of neutrality is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- B. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- C. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
- D. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Political neutrality differs from political indifference** is the controlling principle. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A superior orally orders alteration of eligibility records and refuses to confirm it. What immediate conduct safeguard should the subordinate use? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- B. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- C. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.
- D. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.

Answer: C

Explanation: Written-direction safeguards protect responsibility is the controlling principle. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

Why is seeking written confirmation different from automatically refusing every oral instruction during an emergency? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 place general duties in Rule 3, including integrity, devotion to duty, conduct becoming a government servant, high ethical standards, political neutrality, fairness, accountability, transparency and public interest.
- B. Political neutrality requires lawful service to the elected government without party campaigning, partisan favour or misuse of office. It does not require indifference to constitutional values, evidence, public welfare or lawful policy advice.
- C. Conduct rules should define covered persons, prohibited or required behaviour, exceptions, competent authority, reporting route and consequences. Yet discretion, proportionality and reasons remain necessary where facts differ.
- D. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders.

Answer: D

Explanation: Written-direction safeguards protect responsibility is the controlling principle. Under the CCS Rule 3 supervisory architecture, official directions should ordinarily be in writing where practicable; a subordinate receiving an oral direction should seek written confirmation. This creates clarity without licensing defiance of lawful orders. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

An officer sends a confidential bidder's commercial data to a friend. Which conduct risk is primary? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- B. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- C. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- D. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Official information is governed by lawful purpose** is the controlling principle. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

An employee reports evidence through a legally authorised vigilance channel rather than posting the entire file online. Which balanced information ethic is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- B. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- C. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.
- D. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Official information is governed by lawful purpose** is the controlling principle. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

A serving officer uses undisclosed departmental data in a partisan televised attack. Which combined concerns arise? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- B. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- C. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- D. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Public statements require role clarity** is the controlling principle. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

An authorised spokesperson gives verified information within the approved mandate. Why is this not equivalent to partisan misuse of office? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- B. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.
- C. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- D. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Public statements require role clarity** is the controlling principle. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

An officer's sibling owns a bidding firm, although the officer has not yet favoured it. What ethical condition already exists? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- B. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- C. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- D. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Conflict of interest is a situation, not necessarily corruption** is the controlling principle. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

Why should an investigation distinguish an unmanaged conflict from proved corrupt decision-making? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- B. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- C. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.
- D. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Conflict of interest is a situation, not necessarily corruption** is the controlling principle. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A procurement chair declares that her spouse controls a bidder and then casts the deciding vote. Why is disclosure insufficient? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- B. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- C. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.
- D. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.

Answer: C

Explanation: Disclosure alone may not cure a material conflict is the controlling principle. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A minor widely held mutual-fund interest is declared and independently assessed as immaterial. Why might recusal not be automatic? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Restrictions concerning media connection and criticism of government protect official confidentiality, discipline and perceived neutrality. They should be read with lawful speech rights, authorised academic expression, whistleblowing routes and proportionality.
- B. A conflict of interest exists when a private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It requires disclosure and management; proof of bribery or a biased final decision is not necessary to identify the conflict.
- C. Conduct rules restrict unauthorised communication of official information, but confidentiality is not a blanket defence for illegality. Disclosure must follow law, authorised procedure, RTI exclusions and public-interest channels where applicable.
- D. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility.

Answer: D

Explanation: Disclosure alone may not cure a material conflict is the controlling principle. Disclosure informs the institution, but material conflicts may require recusal, divestment, reassignment, blind management, restriction of access or withdrawal from the private interest. The remedy should match risk and institutional feasibility. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A regulated company offers a luxury holiday to the inspection team before renewal. Which risk remains even if no express favour is requested? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- B. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- C. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- D. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.

Answer: A

Explanation: Gifts and hospitality create obligation and appearance risks is the controlling principle. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A ceremonial item received officially is recorded and handled under the applicable repository procedure. Which institutional principle is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- B. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- C. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- D. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.

Answer: B

Explanation: Gifts and hospitality create obligation and appearance risks is the controlling principle. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

An investigator treats one undeclared entry as conclusive proof of corruption without hearing or valuation. Which due-process error arises? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- B. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- C. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- D. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.

Answer: C

Explanation: Asset declarations are a risk-control instrument is the controlling principle. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

A competent authority compares a return with decisions, seeks explanation and follows the prescribed inquiry. Which proper use of disclosure is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- B. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- C. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- D. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.

Answer: D

Explanation: Asset declarations are a risk-control instrument is the controlling principle. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

A regulator secretly advises a company whose licence she evaluates. Which conduct problem is clearest? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- B. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- C. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- D. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Outside employment and post-employment create divided loyalty** is the controlling principle. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A retired specialist accepts unrelated teaching after satisfying applicable permission requirements. Why should a blanket lifetime ban be rejected? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- B. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- C. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- D. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Outside employment and post-employment create divided loyalty** is the controlling principle. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A Minister uses departmental staff for an election campaign. Which boundary in a ministerial code is crossed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- B. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- C. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.
- D. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.

Answer: C

Explanation: Ministers combine ethical and political accountability is the controlling principle. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

A Minister resigns for misleading the House although no conviction exists. Which form of responsibility is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Property and asset returns can reveal unexplained accumulation and conflicts, but coverage, timing, form, confidentiality and publication differ across legal regimes. They do not themselves prove illicit enrichment or authorise unlimited public exposure.
- B. Private trade, employment, investment and post-employment movement can create divided loyalty, misuse of information or regulatory capture. Prior permission, cooling-off, recusal and tailored restrictions should address actual risk without needless overbreadth.
- C. Gift and hospitality controls address gratitude, access, reciprocity and perceived capture. A sound system distinguishes ordinary social or ceremonial contexts, official dealings, valuation, reporting and approval; monetary thresholds must be checked in the current applicable rule rather than guessed.
- D. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved.

Answer: D

Explanation: Ministers combine ethical and political accountability is the controlling principle. A ministerial code should protect collective responsibility, accountability to the legislature, separation of official and party resources, conflict control, truthful information and civil-service impartiality. Consequences may be politically assigned even where no criminal offence is proved. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A note says the Ethics Committee itself finally suspends a Member without House consideration. Which institutional distinction is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- B. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- C. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- D. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Legislative ethics uses House-owned procedures** is the controlling principle. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A citizen submits a written complaint alleging a member concealed a pecuniary interest. Which official ethics mechanism may examine it? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- B. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- C. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- D. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Legislative ethics uses House-owned procedures** is the controlling principle. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A department launches a code but assigns no office to answer questions or update it. Which implementation failure is predictable? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- B. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- C. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- D. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.

Answer: C

Explanation: Institutional ownership prevents an orphan code is the controlling principle. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

An ethics office publishes guidance, protects advice confidentiality and reports aggregate trends. Which ownership model is being built? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- B. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- C. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- D. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.

Answer: D

Explanation: Institutional ownership prevents an orphan code is the controlling principle. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

Employees can recite the gift rule but cannot identify disguised hospitality through a relative. Which capability is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- B. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- C. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- D. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.

Answer: A

Explanation: Training must build ethical competence is the controlling principle. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

Scenario drills require officials to identify a conflict, choose a management option and defend it in writing. What is the training trying to build? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- B. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- C. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- D. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.

Answer: B

Explanation: Training must build ethical competence is the controlling principle. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A unit claims success because complaints fell after it made reporting difficult. Which measurement pathology is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- B. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- C. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.
- D. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.

Answer: C

Explanation: Monitoring should combine leading and lagging indicators is the controlling principle. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

An organisation tracks anonymous climate surveys, advice demand and repeated control failures alongside proven cases. Which monitoring approach is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A code needs an identifiable steward responsible for interpretation, confidential advice, training, registers, complaints, monitoring, reporting and proposals for revision. Ownership should be sufficiently independent yet connected to lawful decision-makers.
- B. Rule memorisation is insufficient. Ethical competence includes recognising a dilemma, finding the governing norm, identifying stakeholders and bias, seeking advice, giving reasons, escalating safely and learning from near misses.
- C. Rajya Sabha ethics rules empower the Committee to oversee members' ethical conduct, prepare and revise a Code, examine complaints and interests, and recommend sanctions. Committee recommendation and House action must not be collapsed into one step.
- D. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts.

Answer: D

Explanation: Monitoring should combine leading and lagging indicators is the controlling principle. Complaints and sanctions are lagging indicators; advice requests, timely disclosures, recusal quality, training performance, audit anomalies and staff perception can reveal risk earlier. Metrics must not reward concealment or raw sanction counts. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

An employee is dismissed on an anonymous allegation without hearing or identified rule. Which enforcement values fail? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- B. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- C. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- D. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Sanctions require legality, proof and proportionality** is the controlling principle. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

A reasoned order distinguishes inadvertent late reporting from deliberate concealment. Which sanction principle is being applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- B. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- C. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.
- D. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Sanctions require legality, proof and proportionality** is the controlling principle. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

An employee candidly seeks prospective advice, which the same officer later selectively uses to punish her without safeguards. Which design problem appears? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- B. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- C. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- D. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

Answer: C

Explanation: Advice and enforcement must be separated where fairness requires is the controlling principle. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

Separate advice and investigation teams share only authorised records under clear rules. Which balance is protected? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- B. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.
- C. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- D. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.

Answer: D

Explanation: Advice and enforcement must be separated where fairness requires is the controlling principle. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A contractor gives four family members separate benefits just below a reporting trigger. Which ethical failure survives literal threshold compliance? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- B. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- C. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- D. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

Answer: A

Explanation: Loophole compliance can violate the code's purpose is the controlling principle. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A code asks whether connected benefits reasonably create obligation, not only whether one item crosses a number. Which anti-loophole method is used? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- B. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- C. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.
- D. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.

Answer: B

Explanation: Loophole compliance can violate the code's purpose is the controlling principle. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A social-media rule written before digital platforms is never reviewed despite repeated uncertainty. Which governance function has failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- B. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- C. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.
- D. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.

Answer: C

Explanation: A mature ethics system learns and revises is the controlling principle. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

A revised code operates prospectively after consultation and transition guidance. Which learning-and-legality balance is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Confidential ethics advice encourages early consultation, while investigation tests possible breach. Role separation, privilege rules and conflict safeguards prevent an adviser from becoming an unfair witness, prosecutor and adjudicator in the same matter.
- B. Rules are vulnerable to splitting gifts, routing benefits through relatives, strategic ignorance and literal compliance that defeats public purpose. General principles, anti-circumvention clauses, beneficial-ownership checks and reasoned review close gaps.
- C. Enforcement should identify the valid rule, give notice and access to relevant material, use an impartial inquiry, apply an appropriate standard of proof, give reasons, permit review and match consequence to gravity, intent, harm and repetition.
- D. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules.

Answer: D

Explanation: A mature ethics system learns and revises is the controlling principle. Periodic review should use case patterns, court and tribunal findings, technological change, stakeholder experience and implementation data. Revision must preserve legal certainty and avoid retroactive punishment while correcting ambiguous or obsolete rules. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(b): Distinguish between "Code of ethics" and "Code of conduct" with suitable examples. (150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against
books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2.

Model solution

A Code of Ethics states broad values and decision principles that persons in a role should aspire to embody: selflessness, integrity, impartiality, openness, accountability and service. It guides intention and judgment when no detailed rule resolves the case. A Code of Conduct converts recurring risks into specific expected or prohibited acts, procedures and consequences: declare a material interest, refuse or report specified gifts, protect official information, avoid partisan activity and file property returns.

Thus an ethics code asks, 'What kind of public servant and public institution should we be?' A conduct code asks, 'What must or must not be done, by whom, through which process, and with what consequence?' The CCS (Conduct) Rules, 1964 are an enforceable conduct framework. The Second ARC recommended comprehensive public-service values and a Code of Ethics as their complement.

The distinction is not absolute: ethical values may become enforceable when validly incorporated into rules, while conduct rules still require ethical interpretation. An aspirational code is not legally self-executing; credibility comes from joining values with advice, training, monitoring and fair disciplinary machinery.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(a): What is meant by public interest? What are the principles and procedures to be followed by the civil servants in public interest? (150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against
books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2.

Model solution

Public interest is the legally and constitutionally defensible welfare of the community, including fair treatment of minorities and future citizens, rather than the preference of the government, official or numerical majority. It is identified through authorised purpose, evidence, rights and impartial reasoning.

A civil servant should first establish legal competence and the policy objective; identify stakeholders, especially vulnerable groups; disclose private interests and recuse where necessary; gather reliable facts; compare feasible alternatives; and test equality, necessity, proportionality, cost and long-term consequences. Consultation should be meaningful where affected knowledge matters. The officer should give contemporaneous reasons, protect lawful confidentiality, preserve records, communicate the decision and keep review and remedy open.

Codes support this process at two levels. An ethics code supplies public purpose, selflessness and empathy; conduct rules specify conflict, information and procedural obligations. Neither popular demand nor superior instruction automatically equals public interest. The defensible decision is one an impartial institution can explain to affected citizens under law.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q3(a): What is meant by conflict of interest? Illustrate with examples, the difference between the actual and potential conflicts of interest. (150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against
books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2.

Model solution

A conflict of interest arises when a public official's private interest could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It is a risk condition, not automatic proof of bribery or a biased decision.

An actual conflict exists when the private interest presently intersects the decision. For example, a procurement chair evaluates a bid from a company controlled by her spouse. A potential conflict exists when a foreseeable change could create that intersection: a regulator negotiating future employment with a firm that is likely to come under his jurisdiction, even before a specific file arrives. An apparent conflict concerns reasonable public perception and also deserves management because trust depends on visible impartiality.

The proper sequence is identify, disclose, assess materiality, restrict access, recuse or reassign where necessary, divest or use another proportionate control, and record the decision. Disclosure alone is not a cure for a material conflict. At the same time, fair inquiry must distinguish an unmanaged conflict from proved corrupt conduct before imposing disciplinary or criminal consequences.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q4(b): "In doing a good thing, everything is permitted which is not prohibited expressly or by clear implication." Examine the statement with suitable examples in the context of a public servant discharging his/her duties. (150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against
books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 3.

Model solution

The statement rightly warns against administrative paralysis: law cannot anticipate every contingency, and a public servant may need initiative to deliver relief. During a flood, an authorised officer may choose an unlisted but lawful transport arrangement when delay would endanger life, recording necessity and later review.

However, absence of an express prohibition is not unlimited permission. Public power differs from private liberty: the official also needs legal competence, authorised purpose, equality, proportionality, financial propriety and respect for rights. A collector cannot transfer public land to a favoured charity merely because no sentence expressly names that transaction. Nor may a welfare objective justify unauthorised disclosure of personal data.

A Code of Conduct supplies the legal and procedural floor; a Code of Ethics tests purpose, fairness, selflessness and foreseeable harm where wording leaves space. The correct approach is principled discretion: verify authority, compare alternatives, seek advice when time permits, record reasons, minimise rights intrusion and accept audit. Good ends do not create power, but rules should be interpreted purposively rather than mechanically.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV, Section B concluding question: In recent times, there has been an increasing concern in India to develop effective civil service ethics, codes of conduct, transparency measures, ethics and integrity systems and anti-corruption agencies. In view of this, there is a need being felt to focus on three specific areas, which are directly relevant to the problems of internalizing integrity and ethics in the civil services. These are as follows: 1. Anticipating specific threats to ethical standards and integrity in the civil services, 2. Strengthening the ethical competence of civil servants and 3. Developing administrative processes and practices which promote ethical values and integrity in civil services. Suggest institutional measures to address the above three issues. (250 words)

Source / ownership: Faithful English text verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 7. The source PDF's extracted numbering is not reliably attached to this final bilingual block, so the source note does not invent one.

Model solution

Institutionalisation should connect foresight, competence and process. First, each department should maintain an ethics-risk register covering discretion, procurement, gifts, relatives, information, revolving doors, political pressure and digital systems. Near-miss reporting, staff surveys, complaint patterns, audit findings and stakeholder consultation can reveal threats before scandal. High-risk posts need rotation, segregation of duties and focused review.

Second, competence requires more than reading rules. Induction and recurring scenario training should teach conflict recognition, stakeholder mapping, bias detection, reasoned discretion, written-direction safeguards and safe escalation. A confidential ethics-advice office, mentoring and protected consultation allow officials to resolve uncertainty early. Leaders must model disclosure and accept review.

Third, values must enter workflow: clear conduct rules; accessible interest and gift registers; disclosure and recusal protocols; objective criteria; written reasons; tamper-evident records; citizen charters; audit; grievance remedy; and proportionate discipline after notice, hearing and reasoned decision. Aggregate annual reporting should identify recurring risks and revisions without breaching protected data.

Aspirational ethics codes are not self-enforcing, while punishment alone produces defensive compliance. The mature system combines values, advice, capable processes, credible detection, fair sanctions and periodic learning.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2022 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(a): The Rules and Regulations provided to all the civil servants are same, yet there is difference in the performance. Positive minded officers are able to interpret the Rules and Regulations in favour of the case and achieve success, whereas negative minded officers are unable to achieve goals by interpreting the same Rules and Regulations against the case. Discuss with illustrations. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Faithful English text, with extraction spacing normalised, verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf, page 2.

Model solution

Rules create equality, predictability and control of arbitrary power, but language cannot eliminate judgment. Performance differs because officers vary in competence, empathy, initiative, bias, risk appetite and understanding of statutory purpose. A positive interpretation is not one that always approves a request; it finds the lawful route that best serves the authorised objective.

For example, an officer may help an elderly pensioner cure a remediable documentation defect rather than reject the claim mechanically, while still verifying eligibility. In procurement, however, 'positive attitude' cannot excuse favouring a preferred bidder or ignoring mandatory competition. The ethical code supplies service, compassion and public purpose; the conduct code supplies limits, conflicts, records and accountability.

Administrations should issue plain guidance, examples and advice channels; train officers in purposive interpretation and reasons; protect documented good-faith discretion; and retain appeal and audit. Positivity means solution-oriented legality, not personal benevolence above law. Equally, negative literalism should not convert safeguards into avoidable exclusion.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): Is conscience a more reliable guide when compared to laws, rules and regulations in the context of ethical decision-making? Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV-180923.pdf, page 4.

Model solution

Conscience can detect cruelty, unfairness or bad faith that a general rule misses. It supports moral courage when organisational practice has normalised wrongdoing. Yet conscience is shaped by upbringing, prejudice, self-interest and incomplete facts; sincere officials may reach incompatible conclusions.

Laws and conduct rules provide democratically or institutionally authorised standards, equality, notice and review. They restrain personal whim, but can be outdated, ambiguous or used mechanically. A Code of Ethics helps interpret their purpose by stating integrity, impartiality, empathy and public service. It cannot, however, silently repeal valid law or create a penalty by itself.

Reliability therefore comes from disciplined convergence: identify the valid rule; test facts and constitutional values; examine whether the apparent conflict can be resolved by lawful interpretation; seek reasoned advice; record dissent; use authorised escalation, review or whistleblowing channels; and accept correction. In urgent illegality, an official should not obey merely because a superior invokes discipline. Conscience is a warning and reflection faculty, not a private sovereign.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): The 'Code of Conduct' and 'Code of Ethics' are the sources of guidance in public administration. There is code of conduct already in operation, whereas code of ethics is not yet put in place. Suggest a suitable model for code of ethics to maintain integrity, probity and transparency in governance. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Faithful isolated subpart verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 3. This is the direct code-gap question; it is 2024 Q5(a), not 2025 Q5(a).

Model solution

India's model should add an aspirational public-service layer above existing conduct rules, not restate or replace them. Its foundation should be constitutional fidelity, public interest, selflessness, integrity, impartiality, objectivity, empathy, openness, accountability, stewardship and courage to tender honest advice. It should explain these values through Indian administrative dilemmas involving gifts, relatives, data, vulnerable citizens, political pressure and resource use.

Implementation needs an ethics office with sufficient independence to provide confidential advice, scenario training and conflict-management guidance; accessible interest and recusal systems; leadership declarations; aggregate annual reporting; and periodic revision after audit, tribunal and complaint learning. Citizens should know the standards claimed and the complaint route.

Actual misconduct must still be handled under valid service rules and law through notice, impartial inquiry, reasons, proportionate sanction and appeal. The ethics code is not legally self-executing. The model succeeds when values shape judgment before breach, while conduct rules and due process supply enforceable accountability after breach.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): "One who is devoted to one's duty attains highest perfection in life." Analyse this statement with reference to sense of responsibility and personal fulfilment as a civil servant. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 3. This is the requested 2025 Q5(a) route: it concerns devotion to duty, not the direct Code-of-Ethics gap. Topic 16 uses it only for internalisation and Rule 3 linkage.

Model solution

Devotion to duty means sustained, competent and public-purpose performance despite inconvenience, not blind obedience or work without humane limits. For a civil servant, responsibility includes understanding the lawful mandate, anticipating consequences, serving citizens impartially, protecting records and correcting avoidable error. Rule 3 of the CCS conduct framework gives devotion an institutional floor; a Code of Ethics adds service, empathy, courage and stewardship as internal motivations.

Fulfilment can arise when skill and conscience align with socially valuable work: an officer who redesigns an accessible pension process sees public impact and develops professional mastery. Trust earned through reliable service also strengthens moral agency.

Yet devotion is distorted if it means obeying an unlawful oral direction, concealing harm, partisan loyalty or burnout. The officer should seek written confirmation, give candid advice and use lawful review routes. Highest professional development lies in responsible service bounded by Constitution, law, competence and care, not unquestioning compliance with a person or target.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(a): It is said that for an ethical work culture, there must be code of ethics in place in every organisation. To ensure value-based and compliance-based work culture, what suitable measures would you adopt in your work place? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 3. This is the direct 2025 organisational-code question; it is Q6(a), not Q5(a).

Model solution

I would begin with a participatively drafted Code of Ethics stating public purpose, integrity, dignity, impartiality, openness, accountability and service, illustrated by real workplace dilemmas. A complementary conduct matrix would identify gifts, conflicts, harassment, data access, outside work, use of resources and retaliation, with clear reporting and recusal procedures.

Internalisation requires induction and refresher scenarios, leadership example, team discussion of near misses, confidential advice, mentoring and recognition of ethical problem-solving rather than target achievement alone. Compliance requires accessible complaint channels, protected reporting, segregation of duties, audit trails, risk-based monitoring and timely investigation.

Enforcement should identify the valid rule, provide notice and hearing, protect evidence, give reasoned findings, impose proportionate sanctions and permit review. Aggregate annual reporting should disclose trends and corrective action without violating privacy. Staff surveys, advice requests, recusal quality and repeated control failures should inform periodic revision. Thus values guide judgment before a breach, while precise rules and fair process make accountability credible.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: An aspirational Code of Ethics is necessary but cannot be treated as a legally self-executing disciplinary code. Explain. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

A Code of Ethics articulates the kind of public service an institution seeks: constitutional fidelity, selflessness, integrity, impartiality, empathy, openness, accountability and stewardship. It is necessary because detailed rules cannot foresee every dilemma or cultivate motive, judgment and leadership. It guides an officer facing a novel use of data or pressure that no clause fully anticipates.

However, aspiration alone does not define an offence, competent authority, evidence, procedure or penalty. Treating a broad value such as 'courtesy' as automatic dismissal power would violate legality and due process. Enforceability arises only when a competent law, service rule, contract or House procedure incorporates a standard and supplies fair machinery.

The sound architecture therefore separates but connects the layers: ethics code for values, advice and reflection; conduct code for specific duties; procedures for disclosure, recusal and records; and notice, impartial inquiry, reasons, proportionate sanction and appeal for breach. Ethics prevents misconduct; lawfully made conduct rules discipline it.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: How should a civil servant reconcile political neutrality with candid advice and faithful implementation of government policy? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Political neutrality means service to the constitutional government without party campaigning, partisan discrimination or use of office for electoral advantage. It does not mean intellectual silence or indifference to legality. Before decision, the civil servant should give the Minister accurate facts, feasible alternatives, distributional effects and candid warning where a proposal is unlawful or imprudent. Advice should be professional, recorded where material and free from personal party preference.

After a lawful decision, the officer should implement it competently regardless of which party originated it, communicate it truthfully and preserve equal treatment. If an oral direction is doubtful, written confirmation and authorised review protect responsibility. An unlawful instruction should not be implemented merely in the name of discipline.

The conduct code supplies restrictions on political activity, public statements and official information; the ethics code supplies courage, objectivity and constitutional service. Neutrality is therefore loyal implementation of lawful policy combined with fearless, evidence-based advice, not loyalty to a person or party.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Design a conflict-of-interest system for an Indian public organisation covering gifts, hospitality, relatives, assets and outside employment. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

The system should begin with a broad definition: a private interest that could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, official duty. It must distinguish actual, potential and apparent conflict from proved corruption. Covered interests should include financial holdings, relatives and close associates, gifts and hospitality, debts, outside employment, future employment and confidential information.

Operationally, officials should file role-sensitive declarations on entry, periodically and on material change. Procurement and licensing decisions need transaction-specific disclosure. A trained ethics office should assess materiality and choose proportionate management: refuse or surrender a benefit, restrict access, recuse and reassign, divest, use a blind arrangement, or obtain permission under the applicable rule. Monetary gift limits must be drawn from the current notified rule, not improvised.

Registers require secure access, privacy safeguards, beneficial-ownership checks and audit. Anti-circumvention clauses should cover split gifts and benefits routed through relatives. Deliberate concealment may invite discipline only after notice, evidence, impartial inquiry, reasons and appeal. Aggregate reporting and periodic review should identify recurring sectors. The objective is trusted impartiality, not indiscriminate exposure of family privacy or an assumption that every declared interest is misconduct.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Codes fail when they are treated as documents rather than institutions. Discuss the roles of ownership, advice, training, monitoring and review. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

A code without an owner becomes an orphan: employees cannot obtain interpretations, leaders avoid responsibility and obsolete clauses persist. A designated ethics office should maintain the code, issue plain guidance, provide confidential prospective advice, manage registers and recommend revision. It needs sufficient independence from line pressure while remaining accountable to a competent authority.

Training should use Indian administrative scenarios rather than ceremonial pledges. Officials must practise conflict recognition, stakeholder mapping, written-direction safeguards, recusal, information handling, reasoned discretion and safe escalation. Leaders should disclose their own interests and reward ethical problem-solving, not targets achieved by hidden shortcuts.

Monitoring should combine lagging indicators such as proven breaches with leading indicators: advice demand, late declarations, recusal quality, audit anomalies, near misses and anonymous climate surveys. Falling complaints are not success if reporting is unsafe. Annual aggregate reports should state trends, action and learning while protecting lawful confidentiality.

Periodic review should use cases, tribunal findings, technology and stakeholder experience, operate prospectively and preserve certainty. Institution-building durably turns aspiration into ethical competence and precise conduct rules into fair, adaptive practice.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Examine India's ethics-and-conduct architecture for civil servants, Ministers and legislators. Suggest a coherent reform model without collapsing political, disciplinary and criminal accountability. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

India has multiple role-specific layers rather than one universal code. Civil servants are governed by enforceable conduct rules: the CCS framework, for example, covers general integrity and devotion, political activity, media and public criticism, official information, gifts, outside employment and property. Ministers operate under political responsibility and an existing conduct framework involving interests, official resources and accountability. Each House owns legislative ethics through its rules and committee processes; Rajya Sabha rules provide for a code, interests register, complaints and recommended sanctions.

The major gap is not absence of all conduct control. The Second ARC recommended comprehensive public-service values and ethics architecture, while the official 2024 GS-IV Q5(a) itself framed a Code of Ethics as not yet put in place. Such a code should guide constitutional fidelity, selflessness, impartiality, empathy, openness, leadership and honest advice, but must not be described as legally self-executing.

Reform should retain separate institutional routes. Service misconduct requires identified rules and disciplinary due process. A Minister may incur political consequence without a criminal conviction. Legislative breach follows House procedure. Corruption offences require statutory ingredients, investigation and court process. An ethics office can offer advice and training; interest registers, recusal protocols and annual reports improve prevention; independent investigation and appeal protect fairness.

Common minimum principles and interoperable disclosures can connect the system, but one body should not become adviser, prosecutor, judge and political sovereign. Coherence means shared values, precise role rules and distinct lawful accountability.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: A department discovers that senior officials split hospitality benefits among family members, use private messaging for official directions and punish junior officers who seek ethics advice. Propose a complete institutional response. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The facts indicate circumvention, record avoidance, conflict risk and retaliation. Immediate steps should preserve lawfully obtainable evidence, protect affected officers, stop further benefits and separate implicated officials from relevant decisions without presuming guilt. The competent authority should identify applicable gift, conflict, information, record and disciplinary provisions. Anonymous claims require corroboration; accused persons require notice, relevant material, impartial inquiry and an opportunity to respond.

System repair must go beyond punishment. The code should aggregate connected benefits and cover relatives, intermediaries and hospitality, with current notified thresholds and valuation guidance. Transaction-specific declarations, beneficial-ownership checks, recusal and independent reassignment should apply in high-risk procurement. Material official directions should use authorised record systems; oral directions should be confirmed in writing where the service framework requires. Retention and audit controls should address private messaging without disproportionate surveillance.

A confidential advice function should be institutionally separated from investigation, with a clear non-retaliation rule and safe escalation. Training should use the discovered pattern as an anonymised scenario. Monitoring should track advice requests, retaliation allegations, split benefits, late disclosures and repeat vendor links. Reasoned sanctions should reflect intent, value, harm, seniority and obstruction, with appeal.

Finally, publish an aggregate action-and-learning report, revise loopholes prospectively and hold leaders responsible for climate. The objective is evidence-based accountability plus a workplace in which early ethical consultation is rewarded rather than treated as disloyalty. Independent review should confirm that reforms protect both integrity and legitimate employee rights.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.